Free painting – intuition

When we paint freely, with no goal and no effort to make a pretty picture, we often reach for pink when we want **something gentle**, or on the contrary **something that does not fit with gentleness**. But we do not always know why. Sometimes we know exactly why, and sometimes not at all. Both are fine.

What can hide behind a pink stroke

The same pink patch on paper can mean **something completely different each time**, depending on what is going on in us at that moment. That is why it makes no sense to read a picture like a test with one right answer.

Tenderness and care.

Soft, light areas, often around a figure or a heart. A wish to be carefully held.

Playfulness.

Unusual shapes, dots, little waves. A colour that does not take itself seriously.

Infatuation and desire.

More saturated, flowing strokes, raspberry and fuchsia tones. Warmth that does not hide.

Defiance.

A sharp pink next to black or red. A colour that has no intention of apologising.

Sadness beneath sweetness.

Dusty pink, shadows, blurred edges. Something that looks pretty and hurts at the same time.

Memory.

Old porcelain, peonies, a ribbon from childhood. A colour with a specific place.

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Pink in a painting. Can it express what is going on inside?

Yes, it **can** – but it **does not have to**. When painting you sometimes reach for a colour before you can name what you feel. Pink can then give shape to tenderness, anger, emptiness or something you cannot name yet. It can just as well simply be **a pretty colour** you happened to have to hand that day. It gets its meaning only in connection with **your experience**. The colour itself does not know what happened to you. You do, or you will work it out in time.

Art therapy also works with the idea that a picture can express something for which words are hard to find. What matters, though, is not one spot on the paper but **the whole picture** and how it came to be. Your situation, memories, the movement of your hand and your feelings while painting. A predominance of pink alone **is not enough for a verdict** on whether it is tenderness or escape. Perhaps you wanted to allow yourself to be soft. Perhaps the loveliest tube simply fell into your hand.

What if I want to paint it but not wear it?

A painting and a dress may ask two completely different things of you. **A painting can bear your trying it out** without you having to go shopping in it. On canvas you can give pink a huge space without having to accept an idea of how you yourself will look in it.

You reach for pink and a voice says "that will be too sweet". Yet there is only one stroke on the canvas so far. **Try continuing before you condemn the picture** for something it has not even done yet. Pink does not have to depict love. You can paint tenderness, anger, emptiness or something you cannot name yet.

That is completely fine. Sometimes you want to wear it, sometimes just to paint it. A peony on paper and a pink coat in a shop do not rule each other out, but they do not need to go together either.

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When pink takes over the space

First, let your hand work. **You do not have to paint love** or anything cute. Pink can simply be a large unnamed area. The interpretation can wait, and you do not need to choose the right reason before you touch the canvas.

Three things worth noticing

- **QUANTITY**

A detail, or the whole pink field?

A small pink trace can look fragile, but also very decisive. A large area can pleasantly surround you, or start to remind you of an environment you want out of. The amount of pink does not show how much love you have or how much you need care. Notice whether you want it to continue, or whether you need space around it.

- **SATURATION**

Peony or candy floss?

Light powder pink, earthy old rose and sharp fuchsia create completely different impressions. If the light one seems too sweet, you do not have to throw away all of pink. Try a more saturated shade or an earthier companion. Maybe you do not mind the colour, but the form it has had so far.

- **THICKNESS**

Gentleness does not have to mean a careful stroke

You can apply pink in a thick layer, spread it with your palm or let it run. A dense mark can have strength, a translucent one can feel light, uncertain or airy. You do not have to paint tenderly just because you have pink on your brush.

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What to take from the picture

It does not matter what a pink stroke looks like. What matters is what you feel while making it and what is going on in your life at that moment. **Two identical pictures can have a completely different meaning**. One was made in the joy of your own gentleness, the other after a day when you had to put on a nice face. That is why you will not find a dictionary here, but **questions**.

A picture can speak even after time

Perhaps after a while you will notice that pink appeared in a period when you needed to stop forcing yourself to perform. Perhaps it belonged to **infatuation**, **defiance** or the memory of a specific place. In self-reflective work inspired by art therapy, a picture can serve as a trace of your own experience and a way to look back.

Answers often do not come right away

Sometimes you look at what you painted and it tells you nothing. In a week, a month or a year it may suddenly dawn on you: “Aha, this is what I was carrying in myself then.” That is fine. **The picture will wait until you are ready to understand it.**

Neither is wrong and neither is right. **Pink can bear both tenderness and anger**, and often both in one picture.

If very strong or painful feelings appear while painting, do not stay alone with them. Talk about them with someone close or with a therapist. This page does not replace professional care.

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